1.4 NATIONAL GEOGRAPHIC EXPLORER JOHN KELLY



The Birdman Tablet depicts a man with wings and was found on the east side of Monks Mound.

Mounds on the Mississippi

"Cahokia has changed our ideas about ancient Native American culture." —John Kelly

Once one of the greatest cities in North America, Cahokia went largely unstudied for hundreds of years. Then in the 1950s, President Dwight Eisenhower initiated the interstate highway program with a provision for archaeological excavations along the new roads. What the archaeologists found at the East St. Louis, Illinois, mound center astounded them: over a thousand houses that had been built in an amazingly short span of time. What had drawn so many people to the site? Who were they? Archaeologist **John Kelly** has been working on the answers to these and other questions for about 40 years.

^ Highways run on either side of Cahokia's Monks Mound, the largest pyramid north of Mesoamerica. A temple may have once stood on the platform atop the mound. After climbing to the top, a priest would have had a magnificent view of Cahokia's vast floodplain, known as the American Bottom.

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MAIN IDEA Archaeologist John Kelly's excavations of the Cahokia Mounds have provided insight into the city's culture and its rise and fall.

CITY OF MYSTERY

National Geographic Explorer John Kelly has his work cut out for him. We know very little about Cahokia. The people who lived there didn't have a written language. We don't even know what they called themselves or the city they lived in. Cahokia was the name of people who lived briefly on the site in the 1700s, long after the city had disappeared. Archaeologists have pieced together what evidence they've found to expand our understanding of Cahokia. But as Kelly admits, "People still aren't really sure what it was."

According to Kelly, one thing we do know is that people had been living in Cahokia for years. The area was easy to reach along the Missouri, Illinois, and Mississippi rivers, and the land was good for growing a variety of crops, including corn. But why did the population swell from about 7,000 to 15,000 people between 1000 and 1100? One surprising theory states that people arrived after an extremely bright star called a supernova appeared around this time.

For whatever reason, people arrived in Cahokia in large numbers to build a ritual city with houses, farmland, and great plazas for religious celebrations. Above all—literally—they built the mounds. Monks Mound was the tallest. Named for the French monks who once lived in its shadow, the mound rose 100 feet in the center of the city. Laborers toiled on it for about 25 years using only baskets and stone hoes.

RISE AND FALL

Over time, the Cahokians built at least 110 other mounds. Some of these were used as burial sites. Archaeologists working at one called Mound 72 unearthed the remains of a man surrounded by ornaments and weapons. They also discovered the bodies of men and young women buried with and near him. Some were likely human sacrifices.

Kelly has spent much of his time investigating a mound that wasn't used for burials: Mound 34. Actually, his research takes him underneath the mound. The Cahokians constructed a building on top of the mound's platform, but other buildings and a copper workshop stood beneath the mound. According to Kelly, the buildings may have been placed there and covered with earth to represent the view of the world as existing in three layers: the beneath world with Earth Mother, this world, and the upper world. As Kelly says, "We focus on the mounds, but the history's really about the building that was there before the mound!"



Kelly (center) works with students at the site of Cahokia's Mound 34. They are actually standing underneath the mound, which was removed. Artifacts suggest that a special society of hunters or warriors may have used the building that stood on top of the mound. Monks Mound rises in the background.

Around the end of the 1100s, a different kind of construction began in Cahokia. Walls were erected around the city, possibly as protection against attack. But by then, the population had already begun to dwindle and the city to decline. Some say climate change or disease may have led to the fall of Cahokia. Kelly says that a massive flood may have covered the city and caused the people to leave for a brief time. Over a century later, a long drought may have led to the eventual abandonment. What we do know is that, for some reason, by the late 1300s, the residents had left the city. Cahokia remains mysterious to the end.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** What did the Cahokians build in their city?
2. **ANALYZE CAUSE AND EFFECT** Why did Cahokia decline?

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